FiTEN Business Directory

Proposal & Implementation Plan

Building the Infrastructure for Tamil B2B Commerce

Prepared for	FiTEN Executive Committee
Date	May 2026
Version	Draft v1.3
Status	For Review & Approval
Website	www.fiten.org

Executive Summary

FiTEN already has the network. Forty years of FeTNA conventions, speaker rosters, exhibitor halls, and business award ceremonies have built a Tamil entrepreneur community that no platform can replicate from scratch. The missing piece is infrastructure: a way for that network to be searched, accessed, and leveraged year-round — not just at the annual event.

This proposal is not about building a better search engine for Tamil restaurants. Google does that well. This proposal is about building the infrastructure for Tamil B2B commerce — a platform where a Tamil founder in New Jersey can find a Tamil software agency in Coimbatore, where a Tamil VC in Silicon Valley can discover a Tamil startup in Chennai, where a FiTEN speaker's business profile persists and grows long after their session ends.

The FiTEN Business Directory will serve three audiences simultaneously: Tamil entrepreneurs seeking business partners, vendors, investors, and co-founders across the US and India; FiTEN/FeTNA members who want their community membership to have year-round business value; and the broader Tamil diaspora community looking for trusted Tamil-owned businesses.

Key Objectives

- Enable Tamil entrepreneur-to-entrepreneur connections: B2B partnerships, vendor sourcing, investment, and mentorship
- Create the only searchable investor-startup pipeline for Tamil-founded companies globally
- Bridge Tamil businesses across US and India — the only platform with cross-border Tamil B2B context
- Give FiTEN event attendees a permanent professional presence that outlasts the event itself
- Generate sustainable revenue to fund FiTEN operations through tiered listings and advertising

About FiTEN & FeTNA

FiTEN (International Tamil Entrepreneurs Network) is a flagship initiative of FeTNA — the Federation of Tamil Sangams of North America, a 40-year-old organization representing Tamil communities across the United States and Canada. FeTNA connects over 100 regional Tamil Sangams, has hosted 20+ annual conventions, and represents one of the most organized diaspora networks in North America.

FiTEN specifically focuses on the entrepreneur and professional segment of the Tamil diaspora: founders, investors, executives, and business owners across technology, healthcare, finance, real estate, and more. The FiTEN Business Directory is designed to make this network searchable, persistent, and commercially valuable.

Problem Statement & Opportunity

The Problem

- Tamil entrepreneurs have no dedicated platform for B2B discovery, vendor sourcing, or investor-startup matching within the Tamil community
- FiTEN event connections — speaker introductions, exhibitor meetings, networking sessions — are lost after the event ends, with no persistent directory or follow-up infrastructure
- Tamil business owners scattered across the US and India cannot find each other by shared ethnic/cultural context through any existing platform
- Investors and corporate partners have no centralized way to discover Tamil startups and businesses
- The Tamil diaspora lacks a trust-verified business directory — one where a 'Verified FiTEN Member' badge means something beyond a Google star rating

The Opportunity

- FeTNA's 40-year credibility and member network provides a unique trust foundation no competitor can replicate
- Tamil diaspora entrepreneurship is growing rapidly — Tamil professionals are among the most educated and highest-earning immigrant communities in North America
- No existing platform combines Tamil identity, B2B networking, investor-startup matching, and event integration in one place
- The directory can become the year-round digital home of FiTEN — generating revenue, deepening member value, and amplifying FeTNA's mission

Competitive Landscape

The following platforms represent the current alternatives for Tamil business discovery. None of them serve the B2B networking and community trust use cases that are FiTEN's core opportunity.

Directory	Tamil-Specific	Bilingual	Key Gap vs. FiTEN
Google / Google Maps	No	No	No Tamil-specific B2B networking, no community trust layer, no investor-startup matching, no FiTEN event identity.
LinkedIn	No	No	No Tamil filter, no community membership badge, no Tamil B2B context. Global platform with no diaspora specificity.
Tamil Business Pages (FB)	Partial	Partial	Facebook groups only — no searchable directory, no verified badges, no structured profiles, no investment signals.
YellowPages / Yelp	No	No	Consumer-facing review sites. No B2B networking, no Tamil identity, no community trust infrastructure.
India-specific directories	Partial	Partial	India-only scope. No FeTNA community layer, no US-India cross-border commerce view, no investor matching.
FiTEN Directory (proposed)	Yes	Yes	The only platform combining Tamil B2B networking, investor-startup matching, cross-border commerce, FiTEN event identity, and community trust.

Why Not Just Use Google?

Google is the world's best tool for consumers to find a Tamil restaurant nearby. It is not the right tool for the following use cases — and none of these exist anywhere else today:

Tamil B2B networking	Google finds businesses for consumers. It has no mechanism for a Tamil founder to signal 'open to partnership' or for a Tamil vendor to find Tamil business buyers. LinkedIn is the closest alternative but has no Tamil filter and no FiTEN community layer.
Investor-startup matching	There is no searchable database of Tamil-founded startups by stage and sector. A Tamil VC cannot go to any platform and filter 'Tamil-founded, pre-Series A, SaaS, Texas.' FiTEN's directory, with investment-readiness flags, is the only place this can exist.
Cross-border Tamil commerce	A Tamil-owned IT services firm in Chennai cannot signal on any platform that they specifically want US Tamil business clients. A Tamil founder in New Jersey cannot find Tamil tech vendors in India with whom they share cultural context and implicit trust.
Persistent FiTEN event identity	Every year, Tamil founders speak at FiTEN events, exhibit at FeTNA conventions, and win business awards. The next day, their professional identity disappears. A directory with FiTEN event history on each profile turns a 3-day event into a permanent professional record.
Community-vetted trust	For high-stakes B2B decisions — choosing a legal partner, a financial advisor, a tech agency — Tamil entrepreneurs trust a 'Verified FiTEN Member' badge more than a Google star rating. Community vouching is a social signal that no algorithm can replicate.

Proposed Solution

The FiTEN Business Directory is a year-round B2B networking platform and business registry built into fiten.org. It is the organized, searchable, and persistent version of the network FiTEN has already built through its annual events.

Six Core Pillars

1. Tamil B2B Networking — the primary value

The directory's primary purpose is not search — it is connection. Every business profile includes partnership signals: 'Open to Vendor Relationships', 'Seeking Investment', 'Available for Mentorship', 'Looking for Co-founder'. Tamil entrepreneurs can find each other by industry, geography, stage, and intent.

2. Investor-Startup Pipeline

Tamil-founded startups can flag their investment stage, sector, and funding needs. Tamil investors and VCs can filter by these signals to find investment opportunities within the community. This is the only structured Tamil investor-startup matching infrastructure in existence.

3. Cross-Border Tamil Commerce (US + India)

The directory explicitly bridges Tamil entrepreneurs across the US and India. Indian tech agencies can signal their interest in US Tamil clients; US Tamil founders can find vendors with shared cultural context. Cross-border vendor filters and bilingual profiles (EN + Tamil) serve both sides of this market.

4. Persistent FiTEN Event Identity

FiTEN speakers, exhibitors, and award winners receive permanent profile links. Their event participation history — sessions delivered, years exhibited, awards won — persists on their directory profile indefinitely. The directory turns every FiTEN event into a permanent entry in a professional record.

5. Community-Verified Trust

The 'Verified FiTEN Member' badge is awarded based on active membership, not on which listing tier a business has paid for. This trust signal — backed by FeTNA's 40-year history — means something that a Google star rating cannot. Peer reviews from other FiTEN members further layer social proof.

6. Tamil Cultural Context

Full bilingual interface in English and Tamil script. Tamil-language business descriptions, Tamil search queries, and Tamil UI serve both diaspora members and Tamil Nadu-based businesses. Cultural calendar integration connects business listings to Tamil festivals, FeTNA events, and community milestones.

Feature Breakdown by Phase

Feature	Description	Phase
Search & Filter	Full-text search + filters: category, location, language, FiTEN member status, business size	Phase 1
Business Profiles	Rich listing pages: logo, description (EN only at launch), contact, website, socials, gallery	Phase 1
Category Taxonomy	20+ industry categories: Tech, Healthcare, Finance, Food, Retail, Legal, Real Estate, etc.	Phase 1
Self-Service Portal	Business owners can register, submit, and manage their own listings	Phase 1
Admin Dashboard	FiTEN staff can approve/reject listings, manage categories, feature businesses	Phase 1
Language Toggle (EN)	Toggle visible in Phase 1; Tamil option marked 'Coming Soon' — activates in Phase 2	Phase 1
Mobile Responsive	Fully optimized for smartphones and tablets — primary access device for diaspora users	Phase 1
Tamil Language (Full)	Full EN+Tamil bilingual interface, Tamil-script business descriptions, Tamil search	Phase 2
Verified Badges	FiTEN Member, FiTEN Speaker, Women-Led, Minority Business badges with review process	Phase 2
Reviews & Ratings	Community-driven star ratings and written reviews with moderation	Phase 2
Featured Listings	Premium placement at the top of search results and homepage spotlights	Phase 2
B2B Connection Requests	Send/receive connection requests with intent: 'Looking for tech vendor', 'Open to investment', 'Seeking co-founder'	Phase 2
Open-to-Partnership Signal	Businesses flag: Open to Partnership / Seeking Investment / Available for Mentorship / Hiring Tamil Talent	Phase 2
FiTEN Event History on Profile	Speaker sessions, exhibitor years, and awards at past FiTEN/FeTNA events — persistent professional record	Phase 2
Event Integration	FiTEN event speakers/exhibitors auto-linked to their directory profiles	Phase 2
Cross-Border Vendor Filter	Filter for businesses bridging US+India: Tamil-founded US firms with India offices, Indian tech agencies with US clients	Phase 2

Feature	Description	Phase
Email Digest	Weekly/monthly digest: new listings, B2B connection requests, investor-startup matches in selected categories	Phase 2
Investor-Startup Matching	Founders flag stage and sector; investors filter by Tamil-founded, stage, sector, and geography	Phase 3
Co-founder Search	Entrepreneurs seeking co-founders post profiles: skills needed, equity range, domain, stage — searchable by community	Phase 3
Analytics Dashboard	Business owners see profile views, clicks, connection requests, and B2B inquiry volume	Phase 3
Sponsored Listings	Paid banner ads and sponsored placements in search results	Phase 3
Tamil Nadu Integration	Partner with Tamil Nadu government startup registry for Indian business import	Phase 3
API Access	Allow Tamil business associations globally to syndicate listings	Phase 3

Monetization Strategy

The Business Directory will generate sustainable revenue to fund FiTEN operations. Revenue is designed to grow progressively alongside the platform — paid tiers unlock phase by phase so customers only pay for features that are live.

FiTEN Member Badge — Free for All Members

> *Important: The 'Verified FiTEN Member' badge is awarded free of charge to any business that holds an active FiTEN/FeTNA membership. It is a trust signal tied to community membership — not to a paid listing tier. Paid tiers provide enhanced visibility and features, not verification.*

Listing Tiers — Phased Unlock

Free	Silver	Gold	Platinum
Available at launch	Phase 1 — from $9/mo or $99/yr	Phase 2 — from $22/mo or $229/yr	Phase 3 — from $42/mo or $449/yr
Name, category & location	All Free features	All Silver features	All Gold features
Contact info & website	Logo & photos (up to 5)	Priority search placement	Homepage featured spotlight
	Full description (EN only)*	Full description (EN+Tamil)**	Sponsored search result
	Social media links	Email digest inclusion	Dedicated feature article
	Customer reviews enabled	Owner analytics dashboard***	FiTEN event booth discount (10%)
	FeTNA life member benefit		

** Tamil description activates in Phase 2 for all tiers. ** Gold Tamil descriptions launch with Phase 2. *** Analytics dashboard activates Phase 3.*

Monthly billing available at a slight premium. FeTNA life members receive one complimentary Silver listing as a membership benefit.

Additional Revenue Streams

Banner Advertising	Category-targeted ads for businesses reaching Tamil consumers. Price: $300-$800/month per category. Activates Phase 2.
Event Exhibitor Bundle	FiTEN event exhibitors receive a Platinum listing for the event year as part of their exhibitor package. Add-on: $200/exhibitor.
Job Board	Tamil businesses post jobs to hire Tamil professionals. Price: $75 per posting, active for 60 days. Activates Phase 2.

Curated Sponsored Lists	Editorial collections (e.g., 'Top Tamil Tech Companies in NJ'). Price: $200-$400 to be featured. Activates Phase 2.
State of Tamil Business	Annual data report on Tamil entrepreneurship trends. Price: $199 individual / $799 institutional. Year 2 onwards.
FeTNA Life Member Benefit	One complimentary Silver listing per active life member. Subsidised by FeTNA membership fund.

Revenue Projections — Year 1 vs. Year 2

Year 1 projections reflect realistic ramp-up: Silver launches Month 1, Gold Month 4, Platinum Month 7.

Revenue Stream	Year 1 (ramp-up)	Year 2 (steady state)
Silver listings (60 listings, avg 9 months)	$5,400	$10,890 (110 x $99)
Gold listings (20 listings, avg 6 months)	$2,290	$9,160 (40 x $229)
Platinum listings (8 listings, avg 3 months)	$900	$4,490 (10 x $449)
Banner advertising (avg $400/mo, 6 months)	$2,400	$7,200 ($600/mo x 12)
Event exhibitor bundles (15 x $200)	$3,000	$5,000 (25 x $200)
Job board (20 postings x $75)	$1,500	$6,000 (80 postings)
Curated sponsored lists	$600	$4,000 (10 placements)
State of Tamil Business report	-	$4,000 (est. 20 buyers)
Total	**~$16,090**	**~$50,740**

Key assumptions: 75% annual renewal rate on paid listings. Year 2 assumes 30% organic listing growth. Year 1 is deliberately conservative — the goal is to build trust and listing volume.

Technology Architecture

Frontend	Next.js (React) — fast, SEO-optimized, server-side rendering
Backend / API	Node.js with REST or GraphQL API
Database	PostgreSQL — relational data with full-text search
Search Engine	Algolia or Elasticsearch for fast, typo-tolerant search
Hosting	Vercel (frontend) + AWS or DigitalOcean (backend/DB)
Authentication	Auth0 or Clerk — social login (Google, LinkedIn) + email
Payments	Stripe — for Silver/Gold/Platinum subscription tiers
Tamil Font/Locale	Google Noto Sans Tamil + i18next localization library
Email	SendGrid — for digests, notifications, confirmation emails
Analytics	Google Analytics 4 + custom dashboard for business owners

Data Privacy & Security

- GDPR and CCPA compliant data handling for US and international users
- Business owner contact info only displayed with explicit opt-in
- SSL/TLS encryption across all data transmission
- Automated backups with 90-day retention
- Content moderation: all new listings reviewed by FiTEN admin before going live

Rollout Plan

Phase	Timeline	Deliverables
Phase 1	Months 1-3	English-only directory: search, browse, profiles, category taxonomy, admin panel, mobile launch. Language toggle with Tamil marked 'Coming Soon'.
Phase 2	Months 4-6	Full Tamil language, bilingual profiles, verified badges, reviews, B2B connection requests, open-to-partnership signals, FiTEN event integration, cross-border filters, email digest.
Phase 3	Months 7-9	Premium tiers (Silver/Gold/Platinum), investor-startup matching, co-founder search, analytics dashboard, banner advertising, sponsored placements, API access.
Phase 4	Month 10+	AI-powered recommendations, India partner integrations, multi-city curated guides, affiliate & referral programs.

Launch Strategy

- Pre-launch: Recruit 100 founding business listings from existing FiTEN/FeTNA member network — free lifetime Silver tier as founding incentive
- Soft launch: Present at FiTEN Edison NJ event — live demo kiosk and QR code sign-up at registration
- Social media campaign: #TamilBusiness launch campaign across FeTNA Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X
- Community outreach: Partner with Tamil Sangams to promote the directory to their members
- Press coverage: Pitch to Tamil media (Aruvi Magazine, FeTNA Radio, Tamil press in US and India)

Risk Assessment

Risk	Impact	Likelihood	Mitigation
Low initial listing adoption	**High**	**Medium**	Mitigate with 100 founding member listings pre-launch. Offer free lifetime Silver tier to first 100 businesses. Appoint a community outreach lead.
Fake or fraudulent listings	**High**	**Medium**	All new listings require admin approval before going live. Post-approval flagging system. FiTEN member badge requires active membership verification.
Volunteer developer bandwidth	**High**	**High**	Define clear Phase 1 scope before recruiting. Have a contracted agency as fallback. Identify at least 3 developer volunteers before kick-off.
Tamil localization quality	**Medium**	**Medium**	Engage Tamil-fluent reviewers from FeTNA community for UI strings. Use professional translator for launch copy.
Funding gap before revenue	**Medium**	**Low**	Phase 1 development ($8K-$15K) budgeted from FiTEN event surplus or targeted sponsorship call to Platinum-tier businesses pre-launch.
Competition / low differentiation	**Low**	**Low**	FiTEN's member-verified badges and FeTNA community authority are the unique moat. No competing directory has this trust layer.

Success Metrics

Tracked quarterly. Targets are set for end of Year 1 and calibrated to realistic ramp-up — Phase 2 features activate Month 4, Phase 3 features Month 7. Targets marked * are Phase 2+ only.

GROWTH & REACH		
Metric	**Description**	**Target (End of Year 1)**
Total Listings	Approved business listings live on the platform. Starts with 100 founding listings, grows via outreach and organic referrals.	350+
New Listings / Month	Monthly listing submissions — tracks growth velocity. Key leading indicator of directory health.	20+/mo by Q4
Monthly Active Users	Unique visitors browsing or searching the directory per month. Realistic for a niche community platform in Year 1.	4,000-5,000
Search Sessions / Month	Directory searches per month. 2-2.5 searches per active user is the expected behaviour for a business directory.	10,000+
Organic Search Traffic	% of sessions arriving via Google / search engines (not direct or social). Validates long-term SEO strategy.	30%+ by Q4

ENGAGEMENT & QUALITY		
Metric	**Description**	**Target (End of Year 1)**
Listing Completion Rate	% of profiles with logo, full description, and at least 2 contact methods filled. Drives search visibility.	70%+
Email Digest Open Rate	Open rate on weekly/monthly digest emails to subscribers. Industry benchmark for community newsletters: 30-40%.	35%+
Profile Return Visits	% of listed businesses that log in and update their profile at least once per quarter. Measures owner engagement.	50%+

B2B NETWORKING (PHASE 2+, ACTIVATES MONTH 4)		
Metric	**Description**	**Target (End of Year 1)**
Connection Requests / Mo	B2B connection requests sent between business owners per month. Feature is live ~8 months of Year 1; ramp-up expected.	75+/mo by EOY1
Connection Acceptance Rate	% of connection requests accepted. A proxy for intent quality — high acceptance rate signals relevant matching.	50%+

Metric	Description	Target (End of Year 1)
Partnership Signal Adoption	% of profiles with at least one flag set (Open to Partnership / Seeking Investment / Mentorship available).	30%+
Investor Profiles Created	Number of investors/VCs with active directory profiles. Investor-startup matching (Phase 3) depends on this base.	15+ by EOY1

COMMUNITY TRUST

Metric	Description	Target (End of Year 1)
Verified Badge Rate	% of active FiTEN/FeTNA member businesses that have claimed their Verified Member badge. Requires a lightweight verification step.	60%+
Tamil Language Usage	% of sessions using Tamil language mode (Phase 2+, live ~8 months of Year 1). US Tamil diaspora skews to English for business.	20%+
Community Reviews	Total written reviews submitted by verified users. Quality signal for the directory ecosystem.	150+

REVENUE & RETENTION

Metric	Description	Target (End of Year 1)
Paid Conversion Rate	% of total listings on a paid tier (Silver/Gold/Platinum). Consistent with revenue model: ~45 paid listings out of 350.	10-13%
Listing Renewal Rate	Annual paid listing renewal rate. Used as baseline assumption in Year 2 revenue projections.	70%+
Year 1 Revenue	Total directory revenue by end of Year 1 across all streams: listings, ads, event bundles, job board.	~$16,000

Note: B2B Matches Facilitated and Investor-Startup Introductions are intentionally excluded as Year 1 KPIs. Both require a self-report or survey mechanism (to be built in Phase 3) and sufficient investor profile volume before they can be tracked meaningfully. They will be added as formal KPIs from Year 2.

Team & Governance

The Business Directory will be governed by FiTEN's existing leadership structure, with a small dedicated team responsible for day-to-day operations.

Directory Lead	A designated FiTEN board member or committee chair who owns the roadmap, vendor relationships, and quarterly reviews. Reports to FiTEN Executive Committee.
Community Outreach Lead	Responsible for recruiting founding listings, outreach to Tamil Sangams, and managing the FiTEN member badge verification process.
Technical Lead	Volunteer developer(s) from the FiTEN community who own the codebase. Backed by a contracted agency for Phase 1 if volunteer bandwidth is insufficient.
Content & Moderation	Reviews new listing submissions, approves/rejects based on FiTEN guidelines, manages spam and flagged listings. 2-3 volunteer moderators.
Tamil Language Review	Tamil-fluent community reviewers who validate UI strings, business descriptions in Tamil script, and search result quality.

Decision Governance

- All policy changes (badge criteria, listing rules, tier pricing) require approval by FiTEN Executive Committee
- Quarterly review: Directory Lead presents metrics dashboard to FiTEN board
- Community input: Annual survey of listed businesses and Tamil entrepreneur community to guide feature prioritization
- Open-source codebase maintained on GitHub with community contributions reviewed by Technical Lead

Budget Summary

Phase 1 Development	$8,000-$15,000 (contracted agency) or $0-$2,000 (community volunteer expenses only). Includes design, front-end, back-end, admin panel, and initial database setup.
Phase 2 Development	$3,000-$6,000 incremental: Tamil localization, badge system, B2B connection requests, event integration.
Phase 3 Development	$2,000-$4,000 incremental: Stripe integration, analytics dashboard, investor-startup matching, sponsored listing infrastructure.
Hosting & Infrastructure	$50-$150/month (Vercel + managed PostgreSQL + CDN). Year 1 total: ~$600-$1,800.
Search (Algolia)	$0 free tier up to 10,000 searches/month; $50-$100/month beyond. Year 1 estimated: ~$300-$600.
Email (SendGrid)	$0 free tier for low volume; $15-$20/month once digest volume grows. Year 1: ~$100-$200.
Translation (professional)	$500-$1,500 for initial UI string set and launch copy. Ongoing: community volunteer.
Total Year 1 Budget	$12,000-$25,000 (contracted path) or $3,000-$7,000 (volunteer-led path). Revenue of ~$16,000 projected in Year 1 covers operating costs.

A phased funding approach is recommended: Phase 1 from FiTEN event surplus, Phase 2-3 self-funded from directory revenue.

Recommended Next Steps

1. Board Approval	Present this proposal to FiTEN Executive Committee for formal approval and budget authorization. Target: within 30 days.
2. Appoint Directory Lead	Designate a FiTEN board member or trusted community leader as Directory Lead. This person owns the project from this point forward.
3. Developer Recruitment	Post a call for volunteer developers to FiTEN and FeTNA communities. Target: 2-3 developers committed before contracting. Timeline: 30-45 days.
4. Founding Listings Drive	Begin recruiting 100 founding business listings from existing FiTEN member network. Offer: free lifetime Silver tier. Target: 100 listings before public launch.
5. Design & Build Phase 1	Begin Phase 1 development. Target delivery: 90 days from kick-off. Milestone reviews at 45 days (alpha) and 75 days (beta with founding listings).
6. FiTEN Event Soft Launch	Target soft launch at next major FiTEN/FeTNA event: live kiosk demo, QR code sign-up, founding business showcase.
7. Phase 2 Planning	At 60 days post-launch, review Phase 1 metrics and begin Phase 2 planning: Tamil UI, badge system, B2B connection requests, investor matching.

FiTEN Business Directory

Connecting Tamil Entrepreneurs — Across Cities, Across Borders, Across Generations

Prepared for FiTEN Executive Committee · May 2026 · v1.3